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Literacy Learning as Social Practice  
Warner School for Education  
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- 1. Unit Context:** As a student pursuing teaching certification and current teaching assistant at Hilton High School in a 12:1:1 classroom, I plan to eventually teach special education at the High School level. I will begin my K-12 teaching residency Fall 2025 in the Hilton District. Hilton is a suburban district, predominantly white, and mostly middle class, but in special education there is a larger range of economic diversity. This mini unit is designed for 9th - 12th grade students in their CASS (Communication and Social Skills Program) Class to support what is being taught in Social Studies Class where students attend in person. I anticipate students will need a longer time to process and research the information. I also suspect that students would prefer not to present in front of their peers, which is why this unit is based around presenting the material learned in other ways besides a slides presentation. Students will not receive homework because they will all need support while completing the lessons. All students will have access to chromebook devices. All of these students enjoy creating art. All of my students will have IEPs which means that they will receive the accommodations on their IEPs and any other assistance needed to help them reach their learning goals.
- 2. Unit Description and Purpose:** The purpose of this unit is to expand students' knowledge of underrepresented important historical figures. Students will explore the essential question of "why are some historical figures underrepresented?" Answering this question and learning about underrepresented historical figures will help them dive into systemic barriers and historical discrimination such as race, ethnicity, gender, socioeconomic status, disability, and sexual orientation. Throughout this mini unit students will learn about what an underrepresented historical figure is, they will learn about some underrepresented historical figures, and they will work on their research skills, digital literacy, and art literacy. Students will learn about each other's learning and discuss the essential question and relate it to present day systemic barriers.
- 3. Literacies Framework:** The literacies which are embodied in this unit are the same outlined in the framework by Gholdy Muhammad which include Identity, Skills, Intellect, Criticality, and Joy.

**Identity:** Students will have the opportunity to research an important underrepresented historical figure which they feel they can identify with. Students will discover what this person

has achieved. This gives a more holistic view of history and this can help students better understand their own identity.

**Skills:** Students will practice research based skills, history literacy skills, digital literacy skills, and art skills. Students will also practice reading critically, writing thoughtfully, and formulating opinions.

**Intellect:** Students will learn about multiple different underrepresented historical figures. They will be able to recognize similarities in each which will help them understand systemic barriers and historical discrimination. Students will also learn proper research techniques, how to make a QR code and will learn tips on how to create a portrait.

**Criticality:** Students will consider why some important historical figures are underrepresented in history. Students will dive into the role that systemic barriers have on why people are underrepresented, as well as how to overcome these barriers.

**Joy:** Students will engage in creating a portrait of the underrepresented historical figure. Students can choose to draw, paint, color, or create a digital version of their underrepresented historical figure. Art is beautiful and brings joy to people's lives. Students' work will be hung on display for other students to engage in and learn from. This will allow other students to gain a deeper understanding of reasons why some historical figures are underrepresented in history.

#### 4. Lesson Plans:

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| <b>Teacher:</b> Tia Clark                                                                                                                                          |  | <b>Grade Level:</b> 9-12 Grade CASS supporting Social Studies                                                    |  |
| <b>Unit Name:</b> Underrepresented Important Historical Figures Portrait Project                                                                                   |  |                                                                                                                  |  |
| <b>Length of Unit:</b> 2 weeks: 4 lessons (lessons 1 and 4 both take 1 hour, lessons 2 and 3 both take 3 hours) (1 hour per class and classes meet 4 times a week) |  |                                                                                                                  |  |
| <b>Day 1</b>                                                                                                                                                       |  | <b>Lesson 1:</b><br><br><b><u>Engagement Activity:</u></b><br>Historical figures activity. How many do you know? |  |

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|  | <p>Students will take the quiz below to gain an understanding of historical figures and how many they know.</p> <p>Link to quiz:<br/> <a href="https://www.britannica.com/quiz/name-that-historical-figure">https://www.britannica.com/quiz/name-that-historical-figure</a></p> <p>Students then watch the video below as an introduction to underrepresented important historical figures in history.</p> <p>Link to “Three 19th Century Historical Figures You've Probably Never Heard of”:<br/> <a href="https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-9F8NzdFB1Y">https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-9F8NzdFB1Y</a></p> <p>Students are then given the definitions of important and underrepresented and then will answer the essential question.</p> <p><b><u>Essential Question:</u></b><br/> Why are some important historical figures underrepresented?</p> |
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| Day 2 | <p><b>Lesson 2:</b></p> <p>Students are given examples of underrepresented historical figures.</p> <p>Link to examples:<br/> <a href="https://www.namichicago.org/blog/remarkable-women-marginalized-in-history">https://www.namichicago.org/blog/remarkable-women-marginalized-in-history</a></p> <p>Introduce instructions for the project. Remind students of the definitions of important and underrepresented, explain the goal, students brainstorm ideas, review the document, and explain the bibliography page. Answering all</p> |
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|  | <p>student questions and reviewing the brainstormed figures. Every student should have their ideas narrowed down.</p> <p>Link to Instructions:<br/> <a href="https://docs.google.com/document/d/1hcD2jMLkkosOXKRPTiWS--U6E2ttsZYXdq_1oZq8WtU/edit?tab=t.0">https://docs.google.com/document/d/1hcD2jMLkkosOXKRPTiWS--U6E2ttsZYXdq_1oZq8WtU/edit?tab=t.0</a></p> <p>Link to how to create a bibliography on google docs:<br/> <a href="https://support.google.com/docs/answer/10090962?hl=en&amp;co=GENIE.Platform%3DDesktop#:~:text=In%20your%20document%2C%20place%20your,appears%20in%20your%20selected%20style.">https://support.google.com/docs/answer/10090962?hl=en&amp;co=GENIE.Platform%3DDesktop#:~:text=In%20your%20document%2C%20place%20your,appears%20in%20your%20selected%20style.</a></p> <p>Video Instructions:<br/> <a href="https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xbKxWx3VAsU">https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xbKxWx3VAsU</a></p> |
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| <b>Day 3</b> | <p><b>Lesson 2</b></p> <p>Underrepresented historical figure is decided by each student and approved by the teacher. Students start research, answers are put on template and a bibliography page is started.</p> <p>Link to template/writing component:<br/> <a href="https://docs.google.com/document/d/1_EAeMdPVkPKX8yR3EIIGXMWH6O_uT9g1TAnlo22I6ak/edit">https://docs.google.com/document/d/1_EAeMdPVkPKX8yR3EIIGXMWH6O_uT9g1TAnlo22I6ak/edit</a></p> |
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| <b>Day 4</b> | <p><b>Lesson 2</b></p> <p>Students continue to research their underrepresented historical figure and fill in their template and bibliography. Expanding their research skills and knowledge of their historical figure.</p> |
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| <p><b>Day 5</b></p> | <p><b>Lesson 3</b></p> <p>Students finish the research portion, template questions, and bibliography.</p> <p>Introduction to the portrait portion of the project. Students will find portraits of their historical figures online as a reference. Students choose the modality which they will complete the portrait. Students are given access to guides from Elevated Educator on how to draw a nose and eyes.</p> <p>Guide to how to draw a nose:<br/> <a href="https://docs.google.com/document/d/1kXh32ApDC70qNkSar6f_ulG81Sun8VwrcAMEweLGEnw/edit?tab=t.0#heading=h.gjdgxs">https://docs.google.com/document/d/1kXh32ApDC70qNkSar6f_ulG81Sun8VwrcAMEweLGEnw/edit?tab=t.0#heading=h.gjdgxs</a></p> <p>Guide to how to draw eyes:<br/> <a href="https://docs.google.com/document/d/1jFVVHvvI4qAbuV3fc-aEbAEQhAwGOAzahWgwMskrGA8/edit?tab=t.0#heading=h.gjdgxs">https://docs.google.com/document/d/1jFVVHvvI4qAbuV3fc-aEbAEQhAwGOAzahWgwMskrGA8/edit?tab=t.0#heading=h.gjdgxs</a></p> |
| <p><b>Day 6</b></p> | <p><b>Lesson 3</b></p> <p>Students work on creating their portrait of the important underrepresented historical figure. Options for creation are, but are not limited to: drawing, painting, and graphic design. This is aiming to improve students' art literacy skills.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <p><b>Day 7</b></p> | <p><b>Lesson 3</b></p> <p>Lesson on how to create a QR code which links to the template the students created. Students finish their portraits. This works on students' digital and art literacy skills.</p> <p>Link to how to create a QR code:<br/> <a href="https://docs.google.com/document/d/1zTwPFs-6eMk8zvVtBfNl0ZhRR6CwKCG4wBZXLSdU_sU/edit?tab=t.0">https://docs.google.com/document/d/1zTwPFs-6eMk8zvVtBfNl0ZhRR6CwKCG4wBZXLSdU_sU/edit?tab=t.0</a></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

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|  | <p>Video on how to create a QR code:<br/> <a href="https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SnWAumQiJyo">https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SnWAumQiJyo</a></p> |
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| <b>Day 8</b> | <p><b>Lesson 4</b></p> <p>Students finish QR codes. Once finished the portrait and QR codes are hung around the classroom. Students have a gallery walk around the room scanning the QR codes to learn about everyone's important underrepresented historical figures. Students learn from each other's learning. Students then have a class discussion reflecting on the similarities that they are noticing between the types of people that were chosen as important underrepresented historical figures. Then they will share why they think this is the case. At the end of the discussion each student will revisit the essential question of why are some important historical figures underrepresented? This will show growth, learning, and understanding that has been gained from this mini unit.</p> <p>Link to how to scan a QR code on a chromebook:<br/> <a href="https://docs.google.com/document/d/1ZTFM3906Xrd-mEnJsU4iABab_OeBxHC_qHwXmUgCgWc/edit?tab=t.0">https://docs.google.com/document/d/1ZTFM3906Xrd-mEnJsU4iABab_OeBxHC_qHwXmUgCgWc/edit?tab=t.0</a></p> |
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\*Every lesson can be modified to meet the needs of the student

## 5. Create a Sample:

Filled in Template Example:

<https://docs.google.com/document/d/17G8Peqr3WRk-peRXbIll4zc2U27636otJGWe7TZ7hfY/edit?tab=t.0>

Portrait and QR Code Example:

[https://docs.google.com/document/d/15jH\\_7m\\_r0qzt\\_EJcDCGE6ccbMq9Q0KpykHaYsjlBvoM/edit](https://docs.google.com/document/d/15jH_7m_r0qzt_EJcDCGE6ccbMq9Q0KpykHaYsjlBvoM/edit)

## **6. Mini Unit Reflection:**

I found enjoyment in creating this mini unit. I was able to create a mini unit that I would actually use in my classroom. I was inspired to make this my topic when I had conversations with students who didn't know anything about important historical figures that happened to be underrepresented in the social studies curriculum. Some of these people that my students didn't know include Susan B. Anthony, Harriet Tubman, and Sacagawea. However, it was fascinating to me that my students could tell me many things about historical figures such as George Washington, Abraham Lincoln, Martin Luther King Jr, and Alexander Hamilton. This is due to the fact that these people have a strong presence in the social studies curriculum and we have holidays such as MLK Jr. Day and there is an entire musical about Alexander Hamilton's life. This was proof to me that there are systemic barriers and historical discrimination placed in our social studies curriculum. This meant that there was a need for me to come up with a mini unit that would teach students about important underrepresented historical figures. In the process this would teach students about systemic barriers and historical discrimination. I also needed to come up with creative ways of presenting the information and having the students learn about different historical figures they should know without just telling them about these people. Just telling the students would not cover all five pursuits which would limit their learning potential so there was a need for me to be flexible and creative with using multimodal learning formats.

The most challenging part of this mini unit was having to come up with a creative way that would cultivate students' identity and joy along with skills, intellect and criticality. I know that my students have a hard time focusing when a teacher is telling them the information, they do not like presenting in front of the class, and they enjoy creating art. With these things in mind I needed a creative way to meet the needs of my students while including all five of Muhammad's pursuits for teaching and learning.

This assignment has enhanced my understanding of Muhammad's framework by being able to use the pursuits as a checklist for the unit in order to make sure the unit is holistic and diversified to fit the students. This has enhanced my understanding of literacy because there are multiliteracies and this should be shown throughout the unit. This unit focuses on more than just reading and writing literacies. There is also research, digital, and art literacies. This has helped me understand my role as an educator. I now understand the importance of including all of these factors into a unit plan in order for

students to get the most out of the lessons and become culturally responsive critical thinkers.

By focusing on important underrepresented historical figures, I am committing myself to an equity aligned framework, and this is something that I am proud of and will continue to do throughout the rest of my career. I hope to encourage my students to ask more questions and think critically about who they are learning about in history. This will hopefully inspire students to acknowledge and educate to change the systemic barriers and historical discrimination seen in history. I hope to use these lessons in my current or future classroom and I hope to encourage students to learn past the confines of a school curriculum in order to make the world a better and more educated place.